Several companies have confused what was possible with what is useful

So what happens when you take the combo? Do you get the best of both worlds? The simple answer is no. Manufacturers choose a TV model and a VCR model, and just put them both together. The converged product does not offer you as much variety as the individual ones do.

If there are five VCR models you could choose from, and ten TV models, and the features in each of these are to be combined in the new offering, the permutations and combinations are limitless. What is a manufacturer to do? You are, ultimately, stuck with a model of TV that you like somewhat, and a model of VCR that you like somewhat. Here, it's a case of too little choice, unlike with most converged products where the choices seem overwhelming.

Web TV

Television and the Internet have been on a collision course for a long while now—the idea of converging the two into something useful has been doing the rounds for some time. Microsoft's WebTV, which was brought to market around April 1997, is still struggling to get noticed. Time Warner's AOLTV, a combination TV and Internet service, included a TV-like set with a keyboard and remote. It was to enable consumers to watch regular TV and access the Web at the same time.

So what happened? AOLTV has many features such as a program guide and the facility to record shows or remind you when they're on the air. You could watch programmes while simultaneously browsing the Web, exchanging instant messages, chatting about a show or sending e-mail. However, the service was extremely slow and clumsy. It was priced at $249 (Rs 10,800), which included the set-top box, wireless keyboard and remote.

Installation was a painful task. On most Web TVs, it was difficult to get a TV program and a Web page on the screen at the same time, though that's supposed to be the prime feature. Another point is that the picture quality on TV and that of Web pages is, of course, different—most TV screens produce pictures that are 544 pixels wide, while PCs have at least 800-pixel resolutions. So when you try to fit a Web page on a TV screen, the text becomes difficult to read.

E-book readers

Passionate book lovers would have embraced e-book readers whole-heartedly if only it offered the same reading pleasure that a paperback does. There are quite a few in the market, but it is still difficult to find one that serves the purpose satisfactorily. E-book readers, though a good idea, never took off in a big way.

Many factors contribute to choosing a good e-book reader. First comes cost, not only of the reader, but of the downloaded books as well. Size, weight and ergonomics also contribute to the decision to purchase the reader. Then there's readability, clarity, glare, and the reader's ability to handle different fonts and symbols. Low resolutions make the type look strange; reading in sunlight is also difficult.

One example of an e-book reader is the REB 1100, introduced by electronics giant RCA. The company stopped promoting the product for reasons unknown.

Sony eVilla

Sony Corporation's eVilla was an Internet appliance that fit on kitchen counters, and enabled users to surf the Internet, send e-mail, and store music. The eVilla featured a vertical 15-inch monitor, ran on the BeIA operating system, had a memory stick reader instead of a hard drive, and had two USB ports for connecting to Zip drives and printers.

Priced at $500 (Rs 21,750), the eVilla weighed nearly 32 pounds, and was 16 inches in depth. In fact, the manual had directions on how to lift the device!

The product was launched around June 2001, but was hastily withdrawn from the market two months later. Although no clear reason was given by the company, a spokesperson attributed the withdrawal of the product to "falling short of our initial expectations with regard to stability and usability". The operating system also could not cope with the network demands placed on it.

The CueCat

The things companies do to be called 'the first' or to gain attention is best demonstrated by the CueCat. When it was launched towards the end of 2000, the product was highly lauded. DigitalConvergence, the company, designed the CueCat as a cat-shaped barcode scanner about the size of a candy bar. Customers could attach CueCats to their PCs, and the device could read barcodes at the back of products. When a customer swiped one, the CueCat directed the user's browser to a Web page with information about the product.

The designers also envisioned that the CueCat would read barcodes in newspaper and magazine articles, and take readers to related stories on the Internet. The problem: not many people thought that a product that only scanned bar codes was worth investing in.

What Next?

Silicon Film Technologies, Sony and DigitalConvergence may argue, "at least we tried"; but they confused what was possible with what is useful. Companies may churn out converged products by the dozen, but demand will be decided only by the usability and efficiency that the products have to offer.

Moreover, these products were driven by market demand more than the actual evolution, if you like, in the lab. They will, therefore, always remain stop-gap options until the real thing is developed. A cut-paste job will not get convergence far. It will only mar the image of convergence in general, and make the consumer wary of the next device that will be launched.■

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